

The History of Independent Bengal: From the Ancient Age to the Battle of Plassey

Introduction

Modern Bangladesh emerged as an independent nation in 1971 after achieving independence from Pakistan in the Bangladesh liberation war. The country's borders coincide with the major portion of the ancient and historic region of Bengal in the Eastern part of the Indian subcontinent, where civilization dates back over four millennia, to the Chalcolithic Age. The history of the region is closely intertwined with the history of Bengal and the history of India.

The country's early history featured a succession of Indian empires, internal squabbling, and a tussle between Hinduism and Buddhism for dominance. Islam became dominant in the 13th century when Sunni missionaries arrived in Bangladesh. Later, Muslim rulers reinforced the process of conversion by building mosques, and madrassas.

Bangladesh, then Vanga or Bangalah (Vangala), lost her freedom and sovereignty with the fall of the Nawabs after the Battle of Plassey in 1757. Here, the political history of independent Bengal will be discussed in brief.

Etymology of Bengal

The exact origin of the word Bangla or Bengal is unknown. According to Mahabharata, Purana, and Harivamsha Vanga was one of the adopted sons of King Vali who founded the Vanga Kingdom. The earliest reference to "Vangala" has been traced in the Nesari plates (805 AD) of the South Indian ruler Rashtrakuta Govinda III, who invaded Northern India in the 9th century, which speak of Dharmapala as the king of Vangala. The records of Rajendra Chola I of the Chola Dynasty, who invaded Bengal in the 11th century, speak of Govindachandra as the ruler of Vangaladesa. Shams-ud-din Ilyas Shah took the title "Shah-e-Bangalah" and united the whole region under one government for the first time.

The Vanga Kingdom (also known as Banga) was located in the Eastern part of the Indian Subcontinent, comprising part of West Bengal, India and present-day modern Bangladesh. Vanga and Pundra were two dominant tribes in Bangladesh in ancient time.

The Ancient Age

The Aryans entered the Indian subcontinent before 2000 B.C. They developed a cultured society in India. The Aryans entered Bengal after a long time they had come to India. Little information about the lifestyle of the people of the country can be found before the arrival of the Aryans.

Most of the soil except that of South-Eastern part of Bengal was quite old. People used to live here from the pre-historic time. The signs of most ancient civilization have been found on the bank of river Ajay in the present district of Burdhuwan in West Bengal. There is a region called “Pandu Rajar Dhibi”. The archeologists, by excavating, discovered the civilization.

Besides the civilization that grew on the bank of river Ajay, there have been other civilizations too. A country like Bengal did not emerge at once. Many of archeological excavations in Bangladesh revealed evidences of the Northern Black Polished Ware culture of the Indian Subcontinent (c. 700–200 B.C.) which was an Iron Age culture developed beginning around 700 BC and peaked from c. 500–300 B.C., coinciding with the emerging of 16 great states or mahajanapadas in Northern India, and the subsequent rise of the Mauryan Empire. The Eastern part of ancient India, covering much of current days Bangladesh was part of one of such mahajanapadas, the ancient kingdom of Anga, which flourished in the 6th century BC. The other janapadas were Gaur, Banga, Pundra, Harikela, Samatata, Barendra, etc. the exact boundary of these janapadas is not known. However, it is true that their boundaries did not remain the same always. Sometimes the boundary of them increased, and sometimes decreased. Descriptions of some of the janapadas are given below:

Gaur: It was situated in the Northern part of East Bengal in the sixth century. In the seventh century Sasanka was the king of Gaur. Karnasuborna, in the present district of Murshidabad, was the capital at that time. Sometimes before the Muslim conquest, Lakhnauti of Maldah district was also known as Gaur. This region was known as Gaur during the Muslim period too.

Banga: It was situated in the East and SouthEast portion of Bangladesh; its name was originated from the name of a race called Banga. From the old stone inscription, we learn about two parts of Banga – “Vikrampura” in present Munshiganj; and “Navya”, comprising of the low-lying lands of Faridpur, Bakerganj and Patuakhali. It was a powerful region; it has been learnt that the reputed “Banga Raj” and the Banga soldiers took part in many formidable battles.

Pundra: One of the important janapadas comprised of the present Bogra, Rangpur, Rajshahi and Dinajpur districts. The capital of the Pundra Janapada was “Pundranagar”, later named “Pundra Vardhana”. Inscriptions carved on pieces of round stones were found here which are supposed to be the most ancient stone inscriptions found in Bangladesh, made during the time of Asoka in the third century B.C.

Barendra: It was also known as Barendri or Barendrabhumi. It was also a janapada of in North Bengal. It is supposed that it constituted a part of Pundra. A large portion of Bogra district and Rajshahi district was included in the Barendra janapada.

Samatata: Samatata existed as a neighboring janapada of Banga in the East and South-East of Bengal. The Chinese traveler Hiuen Sung travelled to Samatata in the middle of seventh century and wrote an account of it. The area from the East of the Ganga- Bhagirathi to the estuary of the Meghna was included in the Samatata. Many believe that Bara Kamta of Comilla district was a part of this janapada.

Harikela: It is supposed that the present day Sylhet was the Harikela janapada. Though some think that Harikela was not a separate janapada, rather included in Banga janapada.

A well known pre-Aryan kingdom of this region was Gangariddi or Gangaridai, located somewhere on the bank of the river Ganges. It was a powerful kingdom in the time when Alexander the Great invaded the North-Western part of India. Besides, the most ancient Dynasty of Bangladesh “**Maurya Dynasty**” was established before the advent of the Aryans.

Maurya Dynasty (321- 185 B.C.)

It has been mentioned that the Mauryan Dynasty was a pre-Aryan empire. Chandragupta Maurya founded the Maurya Dynasty in 321 B.C. The Mauryan rule was established in North Bengal during the reign of Emperor Asoka (269- 232 B.C.). The region became a province of the Mauryas. Its capital was Pataliputra at first, but later moved to Pundranagar. The archeological site at Mahasthangarh in Bogra still bears the memory of it. It can be learnt from the description of the Chinese traveler Hiuen Sung that the Maurya rule included Karnasuborna (Murshidabad), Tamralipti (Hooghly) and Samatata (South-East Bengal) besides North Bengal. The Mauryan Empire was arguably the largest empire to rule the Indian subcontinent. Its decline began fifty years after Asoka’s rule ended, and it dissolved in 185 B.C. with the rise of the Sunga Dynasty in Magadha. Sunga Dynasty was succeeded by Kanva Dynasty (75-30 B.C.). Afterwards some foreign powers invaded India. Noteworthy among them are the Greeks, the Sakas, the Pahlavs, the Kushanas etc., though there is no valid proof if they came to Bengal.

Gupta Dynasty (320- 550 A.D.)

Gupta Dynasty, rulers of the Magadha (now Bihar) state in North-Eastern India. They maintained an empire over Northern and parts of central and Western India from the early 4th to the late 6th century A.D. The founder of the Gupta Dynasty was Maharaja Sri Gupta (240-280 A.D.), but the empire was markedly founded by Chandragupta I (320-335 A.D.). Chandragupta was succeeded by his son Samudragupta, the celebrated. Some parts of North Bengal came under the Gupta rule during the reign of Chandragupta I. Later he brought the whole of Bengal under the Gupta rule. Only the Samatata remained outside their control. Like the Mauryas, the capital of Bengal under the Guptas was Pundranagar of Mahasthangarh. Gupta rulers spread **Hinduism** in their empire through the building of temples and the promotion of **Hindu** writings

and rituals. During the time of the Gupta Empire, Indian subcontinent as well as Bengal enjoyed a Golden Age in the arts, sciences and religion. The Gupta rule lasted till the middle of the sixth century.

Bengal in Post Gupta Period

The Gupta Empire fell to pieces as a result of the attacks of a fierce mountainous tribe, the Huns. Taking this opportunity many small kingdoms rose throughout the whole of North India. Thus in the post-Gupta period, Bengal too suffered the political unrest that affected North India. Two independent kingdoms came into existence – the kingdom of Banga (Southern region of South-East and West Bengal) and the kingdom of Gaur (Western and Northern region of Bengal).

After the fall of the Gupta Empire, some kings known as the “Later Gupta Dynasty” extended their sway over North Bengal, Northern portion of West Bengal and Magadha. This region was already known as the Gaur janapada. Sasanka was a very powerful ruler of the kingdom of Gaur. The ruler of any big region under the Gupta kings was called “Mahasamanta”. Sasanka was a “Mahasamanta” of the king Mahasena Gupta. He became the king of Gaur a little before 606 A.D by defeating the Maukharis. He extended his kingdom by conquering the kingdom of Dandabhukti, Utkal of Orissa, kingdom of Kanhod and Magadha of Bihar. The kings of Kamrupa were also defeated by him.

Sasanka then thought of conquering North India. This region was divided into two powerful kingdoms – (i) Thaneshwar under the Pushyabhuti Dynasty, (ii) Kanyakubza (Kanauj) under the Maukhari Dynasty. The two kingdoms became friendly as a result of marital relation. Sasanka made an alliance with Devagupta, the king of Malaba to uproot the Maukharis, the perpetual enemies of the Guptas. Grahavarma, the Maukhari king was defeated and killed at the hands of Devagupta even before Sasanka could reach North India. Then he fought against Rajyavardhana, the king of Thaneshwar, and was defeated and killed. Rajyavardhana advanced towards Kanauj. He came face to face with Sasanka on the way. In the fight Rajyavardhana was defeated; later he was put to death. Afterwards Harshavardhana became the over-lord of Kanauj and Thaneshwar. He made an alliance with the king of Assam, Vaskara Varmana and marched against Sasanka to take revenge with a huge army. He could not, however, succeed wholly against Sasanka. Sasanka died a little before 637 A.D.

After Sasanka there was no able ruler in Bengal for a long time. As a result, there were disorder and unrest. The country plunged into darkness. The kingdom was broken into fragments by Harshavardhana and Vaskara Varmana, while the powerful landlords fought against each other. The feudal kings, all of them desiring to become the king of Bengal, fell to arms. This period of political unrest has been termed as “Matsyanayam” in the copper inscriptions of the Palas. When the strong and big fishes catch and eat up the smaller ones it is called “Matsyanayam”. The powerful Lords of Bengal began to swallow the small regions in the same manner. This unrest in Bengal continued for one hundred years. With the rise of the Pala Dynasty in the middle of eighth century this unrest came to and end.

The Pala Dynasty (750- 1160 A.D.)

The founder of the Pala Dynasty was Gopala who was selected as the emperor of Gaur in 750. He subdued the prevalent unrest with the help of the elders of the society. The kings of the Pala Dynasty ruled Bengal for four hundred years at a stretch. No other royal family ever ruled Bengal for such a long period. It had multiple capitals at different stages of the kingdom. Its first capital was in Vikrampur in present day Munshiganj. Later it was moved to Pataliputra, and then to Gaur.

After having restored peace, Gopala turned his attention to the extension of the kingdom. He brought almost all the regions of the North and Eastern part of Bengal under his kingdom. North-East Bengal remained out of Gopala's rule. Although some are of opinion that Gopala ruled for 27 years, some modern researchers believe that he ruled the country from 756-781 A.D.

Dharmapala (781-821 A.D.), son of Gopala, was the greatest of the Pala kings. He established his rule in Bengal and Bihar. His capital was in Somapura in Naogaon district. He fought many fights and wars during his reign, e.g. the "Tripartite War", the battle with King Nagbhata II of Gurjara-Pratihara etc. He was defeated in most of them, though the loss incurred by him was not much. When the Rashtrakuta King Govinda III defeated Nagbhata II, Dharmapala could regain his supremacy in North India. However, Dharmapala conquered Varanasi and Prayaga and extended his kingdom up to the region situated between the middle part of the Ganges and the Jamuna. Some historians say that he also conquered Nepal and reigned for about 40 years. The vast area that Dharmapala established was no longer a kingdom; it became an empire.

After the death of Dharmapala, his son Devapala (821-861 A.D.) ascended the throne as the emperor. He was a worthy successor of his father in respect of intelligence and power. He established his capital in Monghyr (Munger) in India. Devapala had two reputed Brahmin ministers. They were Darvapani and Kedaramisra. Aided by these two ministers Devapala could make successful attacks on the Pratihara and Rashtrakuta kings. The vast region of North India came under the sway of Bengal's King Devapala. The Pala Empire was most widespread during his time.

Evil days fell upon the Pala Empire with the death of Devapala. The later kings were weak. This weakness was manifest mostly from the reign of Vighrapala I to Vighrapala II (861-913 A.D.). Narayanpala (866-920 A.D.), the son of Vighrapala I, ruled for the longest period. But he was weak and inactive. After him, Rajyapala (920-952 A.D.) and Gopala II (952-969 A.D.) ascended the throne one after another. None of them were worthy enough to be the successors of the Pala Dynasty; as a result the Empire started to break down and its region started to shrink.

When the Pala Empire was on the verge of destruction, Mahipala I (995-1043 A.D.), son of Vighrapala II (969-995 A.D.), came forward with a ray of hope. He liberated North and West Bengal from the clutches of foreign powers and founded the capital in Mahipal in present day Murshidabad. He checked the fall of the Pala Empire and brought back its former glory. But Mahipala could not leave a worthy successor. With his death the empire broke down

immediately. After him, his son Nayapala (1043-1058 A.D.) and his grandson Vighrahapala III (1058-1075 A.D.) ascended the throne. They could not protect the empire from foreign attacks. Bihar, outside Bengal began to slip away. During the reign of Vighrahapala III, the Pala Empire in Bengal broke into many pieces.

The difficult situation became comparatively tense in the reign of Mahipala II (1075-1080 A.D.). The landlords of North Bengal openly revolted in the Barendra region which is known as the “Kaivarta” rebellion in history. Mahipala II was killed by the rebels and the Kaivarta leader Divya or Divyak captured power in the Barendra region.

In the meantime, Surapala II, the younger brother of Mahipala II, ascended the Pala throne. He ruled for two years. Thereafter, his youngest brother, Rampala (1082-1124 A.D.) became the king. He was the last successful ruler of Pala Dynasty. The ancient poet of Bengal, Sandhakara Nandi, wrote a biography of Rampala called *Ramcharita*. We can learn about his life from it.

Rampala tried to recover Barendra from the clutches of the Kaivartas. He failed in the first attempt. Later he went for the second attempt with the help the kings of fourteen regions, including Rashtrakuta, Magadha and Rahr who helped him with soldiers, arms and money. In the war the Kaivarta king Bhima was defeated and killed. Rampala tried to bring peace to the country after recovering Barendra. He established a new capital called Ramavati near the present Maldah. In order to regain the lost glory, he exercised supremacy over Magadha and Kamrupa. But it was unfortunate that the succeeding Pala kings were very weak. It was not possible for them to save the Pala Empire. After Rampala, Kumara Pala (1124-1129 A.D.), Gopala III (1129-1143 A.D.) and Madana Pala (1143-1161 A.D.) ascended the throne of the Pala Empire one after another. Some historians pointed out that there was one more king of the Pala Dynasty after Madana Pala named Govindapala; though the span of his reign cannot be exactly determined. However, during this time, warfare became an everyday affair. As a result, decadence began which gradually led to the collapse of the Pala Dynasty.

The Independent Kingdom of South-East Bengal

The South-East Bengal was independent most of the time during the time of the Palas. This region was in the “Banga” janapada of the ancient time. From the middle of the eighth century A.D. many dynasties ruled in this region.

The Kharga Dynasty: Founded in South-East Bengal (Tripura and Noakhali) in the second half of the seventh century; the capital was “Karmanta Vasaka”, supposed to be the ancient name of “Bara Kamta” of Comilla.

The Deva Dynasty: Founded in the same region in the eighth century, succeeding the Kharga Dynasty. Renowned kings of this family were Sri Shanti Deva, Sri Ananda Deva and Sri Bhaba Deva. They were also Buddhists. Their capital was in Deva Parbata near Mainamoti in Comilla. The kingdom was extended throughout the whole of the Samatata region. The famous Buddhist monastery “Ananda Vihara” was built by King Ananda Deva. The Deva kings ruled approximately from 740 A.D. to 800 A.D.

The Kingdom of Kanti Deva: An independent state, founded by King Kanti Deva, arose in the ninth century in Harikela and South Bengal. The present day Sylhet was the kingdom and its capital was Burdwanpur – which has no existence today. No descendants of this Buddhist king have been found. This kingdom was succeeded by the Chandra Dynasty.

The Chandra Dynasty: The most powerful independent kingdom of South-East Bengal, ruled for about 150 years. Its founder was Purna Chandra, succeeded by his son Subarna Chandra, and later by his grandson Troilakya Chandra – the first powerful king of this family.

Its main center was the Lalmai hills of Comilla, known as Rohitagiri then. Troilakya Chandra (900-930 A.D.) occupied the whole of East and South-East Bengal. Later, his son Sri Chandra (930-975 A.D.) extended the kingdom upto North-East Kamrupa and Gaur in the north, setting up the capital in Vikramapura.

The other kings of this family were Kalyan Chandra (975-1000 A.D.), Ladaha Chandra (1000-1020 A.D.) and Govinda Chandra (1020-1045 A.D.). The dynasty fell when the Chola Dynasty and Kalchuri Dynasty attacked Banga.

The Varmaraja Dynasty: Established at the end of the eleventh century in South-East Bengal. They are supposed to come to this country with Karna, the king of Kalchuri. The Dynasty was founded by Jatavarma, the son of Brajavarma. Their capital was in Vikramapura. The kingdom was succeeded by Harivarma, who ruled for 46 years and extended the kingdom upto Nagabhumi (Nagaland) and Assam. The subsequent kings were Shyamalvarma and Bhojavarma. The Varma family perished soon after King Vijay Sena of the Sena Dynasty occupied South-East Bengal in the middle of twelfth century.

Sena Dynasty (1070-1230 A.D.)

The Sena Empire was a Hindu dynasty that ruled from Bengal through the 11th and early 13th centuries. The empire at its peak covered much of the north-eastern region of the Indian subcontinent. The rulers of the Sena Dynasty traced their origin to the south Indian region of Karnataka of the Deccan. According to some, they were Brahmakhatryia. At first they were Brahmins. Later when they became skilled in warfare, they earned the title “Khatrya”.

The founder of Sena Dynasty was Samanta Sena, who came to Bengal in his old age, making his settlement in the Rahr region on the bank of the river Ganges. As he did not establish a kingdom, the honor of being a king was given to his son Hemanta Sena. Thus Hemanta Sena (1070-1098) is regarded as the founder of Sena Empire, who was supposed to be a feudal king under the Pala Emperor Rampala. His successor Vijay Sena (1098-1160 A.D.) helped laid the foundations of the dynasty, and had an unusually long reign of over 60 years. He brought East and South Bengal under his reign defeating the Varma king. Then he conquered North-West Bengal, Kamrupa, Kalinga and Mithila. His first capital was Vijayapura in Triveni of Hooghly district. The second capital was established in Vikramapura.

Vallala Sena (1160-1178 A.D.), son of Vijay Sena, conquered Gaur from the Pala, became the ruler of the Bengal Delta, and made Nabadwip the capital as well. Vallala Sena married Ramadevi, a princess of the Western Chalukya Empire which indicates that the Sena rulers maintained close social contact with South India.

Lakhshmana Sena (1178-1206 A.D.) succeeded Vallala Sena, ruled Bengal and expanded the Sena Empire to Assam, Odisha, Bihar, Proyaga, and probably to Varanasi. Coming to the end of his reign Lakhshmana Sena became quite weak. As a result, the feudal lords around him started to revolt. Well known rebel kings of that time were Dommanpala of Sundarban area (1196 A.D.), Pattikera of South-East Bengal and King Ranabankamalla Deva.

In the beginning of the thirteenth century, the Muslim power from the North began to proceed towards Bengal. The Muslim commander Ikhtiaruddin Muhammad Bakhtiar Khalji attacked Nadia, the second capital of Sena Dynasty. Being defeated Lakhshmana Sena fled to East Bengal. North and North-West Bengal went under the Muslim rule. Lakhshmana Sena ruled for more two years and died in 1206 A.D. Though the Sena rule continue for some time more, it can be very well be said that with the defeat of Lakhshmana Sena the Sena rule in Bengal came to an end.

Medieval Age

The Medieval Age in Bengal started in the thirteenth century. The main feature of this age is the end of the Hindu and Buddhist rule and the establishment of the Muslim rule in Bengal. In 1203 A.D. the Turkish hero Bakhtiar Khalji conquered Bihar near Bengal. The inhabitants of Nadia were very afraid of the Turkish. The trained warrior Bakhtiar Khalji chose to advance through the jungle of Jharkhand instead of the mountain pass of Teliaghri. He divided his army into small groups and entered Nadia with the first group consisting 17 or 18 soldiers. The people of Nadia thought that a band of horse merchant has come, so nobody stopped them. Bakhtiar Khalji occupied the Palace of Lakhshmana Sena; there rose a hue and cry; the other soldiers entered Nadia and Lakhshmana Sena fled to East Bengal. Thus Nadia came into the hands of the Muslims.

In 1205 A.D. Bakhtiar Khalji took hold of the famous capital of Sena Dynasty, Lakhsmanabati. He renamed it as Lakhnauti. But he established the capital at Devakota in Dinajpur and did not entered into Bengal any farther. He failed in the expedition of Tibet and came back to Devakota. He died in 1206 A.D.

Bakhtiar Khalji wanted to establish independent rule in Bengal permanently, so he divided the conquered region into number of provinces or districts called “Ikta”. He established many mosques and madrassas for the development of Muslim society and culture. Thus began the Muslim rule in Bengal.

The Turkish Rule (1204-1338 A.D.)

The rulers of this period were not fully independent. Some of them who came as soldiers were Khalji Malliks, while others were rulers of Turkish blood appointed by the Sultans of Delhi. Later many rulers revolted against Delhi and attempted to be independent. But they all failed in the end. The historian from Delhi, Ziauddin Barani named Bengal as “Bulgakpur”, which means “City of Rebellion”.

In 1208, Bakhtiar Khalji’s fellow warrior Hushamuddin Iwaj Khalji became the ruler of Devakota. Later he voluntarily handed over the rule to Ali Mardan Khalji. Ali Mardan took the name of Alauddin Ali Mardan Khalji and declared independence in 1210 A.D. But he was a very stern ruler. As a result, the Khalji Malliks revolted against him and killed him. Iwaj Khalji came to the power of Bengal for the second time as an independent Sultan in the name of Giasuddin Iwaj Khalji. He ruled from 1212 A.D. to 1227 A.D. He expanded the Muslim rule in Bengal, introduced coins bearing his name and built many mosques, madrassas and roads. The credit of building the first naval force in Bengal goes to him. But the Sultan of Delhi apparently did not accept Bengal becoming independent in such a manner. Iwaj Khalji was killed in 1227 A.D. by the soldiers of Sultan Iltumish.

After his death, the “Slave Rule” started in Bengal, when Bengal was reduced to a province of the Muslim Sultan of Delhi upto 1287 A.D. Ten of the fifteen rulers of that time were “Mamluks” or slaves. They all were of Turkish origin, so it can be called the Age of Turks. During that time, there was internal conflict in Delhi; so the Turkish rulers ruled quite independently. The first Turkish ruler was Nasiruddin Mahmud, the son of Sultan Iltumish. He was succeeded by Daulat Shah Bin Moudad. The conflict in Delhi started with the death of Sultan Iltumish in 1236 A.D. Awor Khan Aibek captured power in Lakhnauti. But the ruler of Bihar, Tughril Tughan Khan defeated him and ruled Bengal till 1245 A.D. The next rulers were as follows:

1. **Omar Khan** (1245-1247 A.D.)
2. **Jalaluddin Masud Jani** (1247-1251 A.D.)
3. **Malik Ikhtiaruddin Uzbek “Mughisuddin”** (1251- 1257 A.D.); ruler of Oudh, expanded the frontier; was killed.
4. **Malik Izzauddin Uzbek** (1257-1259 A.D.); independent.
5. **Tazuddin Arsalan Khan**; ruler of the *Kara* Province; became the ruler in 1269 A.D.
6. **Tatar Khan**; first pledged allegiance to Delhi, later cut off relation in a few years. He was succeeded by **Sher Khan** for some time.
7. **Tughril “Mughisuddin”**; greatest of the Mamluk Turks. Brought North and West Bengal, Dhaka and some region of Faridpur under rule. Built the fort “Narkilla” or “Tughril’s Killa” near Sonargaon; declared independence. Was attacked by Sultan Balban of Delhi, and defeated and killed in 1281 A.D.

Sultan Balban appointed his son Bughra Khan as the Governor of Bengal. After Balban’s death in 1287 A.D. Bughra Khan took up the name of Nasiruddin Mahmud Shah and became the

independent Sultan of Bengal. His son Kaikobad was the Sultan of Delhi. At the news of Kaikobad's death, disheartened Bughra Khan handed over the throne to his other son Rukanuddin Kaikaus (1291-1300 A.D.). After Kaikaus, Malik Firoz Itgin became the Sultan in the new name of Shamsuddin Firoz Shah, followed by his son Giasuddin Bahadur Shah. He was made a prisoner by the Sultan of Delhi, Giasuddin Tughlak, later was freed in 1325 A.D. and sent to Sonargaon. There he ruled jointly with Bahram Khan. In 1328 A.D. Giasuddin Bahadur revolted and was killed by Bahram Khan. Henceforth, Bengal remained under control of Delhi upto 1338 A.D.

The Independent Sultanate (1338-1538 A.D.)

The ruler of Sonargaon, Bahram Khan died in 1338. The armourer of him was Fakhrah, who was a royal employee. He declared independence and ascended the throne of Sonargaon with the name Fakhruddin Mubarak Shah. It was the beginning of the independent Sultanate in Bengal. The Sultan of Delhi, Muhammad bin Tughlak, has no time to look into the matters in far-off Bengal. Kader Khan, the ruler of Lakhnauti and Izzauddin, the ruler of Satgaon jointly attacked Sonargaon, but they failed. Kader Khan was defeated and killed by the soldiers of Fakhruddin.

From the dates engraved on the coins issued by Fakhruddin, it is supposed that he ruled Sonargaon from 1338 A.D. to 1349 A.D. He extended the area of his kingdom in the NorthWest direction. He conquered Chittagong and built a highway from Chandpur to Chittagong. In 1348 A.D. coins were issued from the mint of Sonargaon having the name of Ikhtiar Gazi Shah (assumed as the son of Fakhruddin) inscribed on them; these coins dated upto 1352 A.D. have been found. Gazi Shah ruled Sonargaon for three years after the death of his father till 1352 A.D.

Haji Ilias, foster brother of Alauddin Ali Shah – the ruler of Lakhnauti, defeated and killed Ali Shah in 1342 A.D. and ascended the throne of Pandua (Firozabad) becoming the master of North and North-West Bengal. He brought Satgaon under his sway in 1346 A.D. and also invaded Nepal and conquered some portions of Trihut and North Bihar. Finally in 1352 A.D. he defeated Ikhtiaruddin Gazi Shah and established a Dynasty in Bengal. The conquest of Bengal was made complete with this. Described as “Shah-e-Bangalah” and “Shah-eBangalian” by the historian of Delhi Shams-e-Shiraj Afif, Ilias Shah conquered some parts of Champaran, Gorakhpur and Kashi outside Bengal.

The Sultan of Delhi, Firoz Shah Tughlak waged war against Ilias Shah from November 1353 A.D. to September 1354 A.D. He was not successful and had to accept the independence of Bengal. He made friendship with Ilias Shah and returned to Delhi. When Sikander Shah (1358-1393 A.D.) succeeded his father, Firoz Shah Tughlak again attacked Bengal from 1358 A.D. to 1360 A.D. and failed once again. The independent Sultanate in Bengal was strengthened by Sikander Shah. His son Giasuddin Azam Shah (1393-1411 A.D.) was the most popular Sultan of the age. He could keep united the vast kingdom without any warfare as an able ruler.

The Rule of the Dynasty of Raja Ganesh

The independent Sultanate in Bengal did not continue for two hundred years at a stretch. There was a short interval in the long period. After Giasuddin Azam's death, his son Saifuddin Hamza Shah ascended the throne in 1411 A.D. But he was killed by his slave Shihabuddin in 1412 A.D. as a result of a conspiracy. Shihabuddin became the Sultan as Shihabuddin Bayazid Shah, and got murdered too in two years. Taking this advantage, Raja Ganesh, a high official of Azam Shah assumed power of Bengal.

Ganesh put to death many Muslim Sufis and Saints. Sultan Ibrahim Sharki of Jaunpur came forward to save the Muslims. Frightened, Ganesh compromised with Dervish leader Noor Kutub; made his son Jadu accept the religion of Islam, changing Jadu's name to Jalaluddin Mahmud; and left the throne in his charge in the middle of 1415 A.D.

After Sharki's leave, Ganesh again ascended the throne and brought his son back to the Hindu faith. But Ganesh died in 1418 A.D. and Jadu succeeded the throne as Jalaluddin Mahmud Shah again; he was a devoted Muslim. Jalaluddin Mahmud ruled till 1432 A.D. He moved the capital to Gaur from Pandua. He was succeeded by his son Shamsuddin Ahmed Shah, who was killed by his slave Nasir Khan in 1433 A.D. Thus ended the thirty years' rule of Raja Ganesh and his descendents.

Later Ilias Shahi Rulers

The elite society became agitated because a slave had murdered his master and ascended the throne. They united attacked and killed Nasir Khan. In 1452 A.D. they placed on the throne of Bengal Nasir Shah, a descendent of Ilias Shah. He is known as Nasiruddin Mahmud Shah in history.

Nasiruddin Mahmud Shah (1452-1459 A.D.): The boundaries of Bengal extended.

Rukanuddin Barbak Shah (1459-1474 A.D.): Son of Nasiruddin Mahmud, appointed ruler of Satgaon. He employed about eight thousand slaves in different offices.

Shamsuddin Abu Zafar Yusuf Shah (1474-1481 A.D.): Son of Barbak Shah, an ideal and competent ruler. After him, his son Sikander Shah ascended the throne. But he was removed because of his sickness.

Jalaluddin Fateh Shah (1481- 1487 A.D.): Younger brother of Yusuf Shah. There was internal chaos in the Royal court. The slaves imported by his predecessors became very powerful. Fateh Shah lost his life while attempting to curb their power.

The Habshi Rule (1487-1493 A.D.)

This period was filled with lawlessness, injustice, conspiracy, rebellion and despair. All the four Habshi Sultans were killed during this period.

Barbak Shahjada: Habshi leader, first to ascend the throne, was killed within a few months.

Saifuddin Firoz Shah: Originally slave Commander Malik Andil, killed Barbak Shahjada.

Ruled for three years with glory. Later was killed by the Palace Guards.

Nasiruddin Mahmud Shah II: Third Habshi ruler was killed after reigning for some time.

Shamsuddin Muzaffar Shah (1491-1493 A.D.): Slave leader, killer of Nasiruddin II. Tyrant and murderer. Nobles of Gaur revolted against him. His minister joined hands with the rebels. Ultimately he was killed and it ended the Habshi rule in Bengal.

Hussain Shahi Dynasty (1493-1538 A.D.)

Alauddin Hussain Shah (1493-1519 A.D.): Originally known as Syed Hussain, belonged to the Syed family of Arabia; the founder of Hussain Shahi Dynasty – the most successful one among the independent Sultans of Bengal.

He was the greatest Sultan of this dynasty. He conquered Kamrupa, Kamta, some parts of Orissa and Tripura, and parts of North and South Bihar. He drove away the Arakanians from Chittagong, but failed in the expedition of Assam. Sikander Lodi, the Sultan of Delhi attacked Bengal during this time, but could not succeed. Hussain Shah was successful in taking all sorts of security measures for his vast kingdom. He died in 1519.

Nusrat Shah; later **Nasiruddin Abul Mazaffar Nusrat Shah (1519-1531 A.D.):** Son of Hussain Shah. Almost the whole of Bihar came under his sway. It was the time when Mughal Empire established in India. The first Mughal Emperor Babur sent an expedition to Bengal. Nusrat Shah first made friendship with him; but when war broke out, he concluded a treaty with Babur and made the throne of Bengal safe. Bengal had conflicts with the state of Ahom. Nusrat Shah was assassinated in 1531.

Alauddin Firoz Shah (1531-1533 A.D.): Son of Nusrat Shah, ruled for about one year. The conflicts with Ahom continued. Decline of the independent Sultanate began during his reign. He was killed in 1533.

Giasuddin Mahmud Shah (1533-1538 A.D.): Brother of Nusrat Shah, killed Firoz Shah and ascended the throne. Could not bring peace in the kingdom. He kept indulging in fights with the Afghan leader Sher Shah Shuri, until Sher Shah captured Gaur in 1538. With Giasuddin's death, the 200 years of the independent rule of Bengal ended. The foreign powers began to grab Bengal one after another.

The Rule of the Afghans and the Mughals in Bengal

The Mughal Emperor Humayun occupied the capital of Bengal for a short period. He had to accept defeat at the hands of Sher Shah. Bengal and Bihar directly came in the hands of the Afghans. The two sections of the Afghans, Shur Afghans and Karrani Afghans ruled Bengal for quite some time. At last, the Mughal Emperor Akbar snatched the power of Bengal from the Afghans. But the Mughals could not establish their rule throughout Bengal for a long time. At that time, there were a number of big independent 'Zamindars' in Bengal. These landlords known as 'Barabhuyinas' did not recognize the supremacy of the Mughals. The Mughal Subadars failed, later the 'Barabhuyinas' were subdued during the reign of Jahangir.

The Afghan Rule (1538-1576 A.D.)

The founder of the Afghan rule in Bengal was Sher Khan Shur. His father Hasna Khan Shur was the Jagirdar of Sassaram in Bihar. After his death, Sher Khan became the Jagirdar. He also assumed the guardianship of the Jagirdar of Bihar, Jalal Khan as he was still a minor.

Sher Khan dreamt of being the lord of the whole of India. He began to increase his power secretly. He occupied Chunar, Bihar and Bengal in a short time. The Mughal Emperor Humayun then became alert. The Mughals failed to bring Bengal under their control because of the Afghan resistance. Humayun was locked in war with Sher Khan. He snatched away the fort of Chunar and Bihar from Sher Khan; he also occupied the capital of Bengal, Gaur. Being charmed by the beautiful Palace and the natural beauty of Gaur, he named it 'Jannatabad' and indulged in merrymaking for six months. In the meantime Sher Khan began to increase his power. News came from Delhi that the step-brother of Humayun, Hindal was plotting to seize the throne. Hearing the news Humayun started for Delhi. Sher Khan availed himself for the opportunity. He laid ambush in Chausa near Buxar. When Humayun reached there on the bank of the river Ganges, Sher Khan fell upon him. Taken aback, Humayun was defeated.

Sher Khan took up the title "Sher Shah" after defeating Humayun and declared himself as the independent Sultan of Bihar. In 1540 he defeated the Mughal administrator Ali Kuli and occupied Bengal. In that same year he occupied the throne of Delhi by defeating Humayun. After a long time Bengal again went under the rule of Delhi. The whole Bengal upto Chittagong and Sylhet came under the domain of Sher Shah. The rule of Bengal during this period was called the rule of the Shur Afghan Dynasty after the title of Sher Shah.

Bengal remained under Delhi upto the reign of Islam Shah (1545-1553 A.D.), son of Sher Shah. After him, the Delhi Empire began to crumble due to factionalism among Afghan leaders. At this opportunity the Afghan ruler Muhammad Shah Shur declared independence of Bengal. He was defeated by the Sultan of Delhi, Muhammad Adil Shah Shur. The Shur rule extended upto Arakan.

When Muhammad Shah Shur was killed in 1555, his son Bahadur Shah Shur ascended the throne of Gaur. He killed his master Adil Shah Shur, the killer of his father. After his death, his brother Jalal Shah became the Sultan of Gaur. Thereafter one Giasuddin Karrani killed the son of Jalal Shah and seized the throne of Bengal. Thus the rule of the Karrani Afghans began, ending the Shur Afghan rule.

Taj Khan Karrani was the commander and counselor of Islam Shah. He conquered Bengal in 1564 A.D. After his death, his brother Sulaiman Karrani became the Sultan of Bengal. This efficient ruler gathered all Afghan leaders to his side and established his authority in Bengal, Bihar and Orissa. He maintained good relation with the Mughal Emperor Akbar. When Sulaiman died in 1572 A.D. his son Bayazid ascended the throne. In a short time this tyrant ruler was put to death by the Afghan leaders. Sulaiman's second son Daud Karrani then ascended the throne. He was the last Afghan ruler in Bengal. He was an imprudent ruler. The vast empire, wealth and riches made him feel equivalent to Emperor Akbar. By then the rulers of Bengal and Bihar pledged allegiance openly to the Mughal Emperor. On the contrary, Daud Khan Karrani assumed the title 'Badshah' and also issued coins bearing his name.

As the Afghans had already been enemies of the Mughals and Emperor Akbar also was not at ease as Bengal and Bihar were not under the Mughal authority, the conduct of Daud Karrani offered a pretext to Akbar to attack Bengal. The ruler of Juanpur, Munim Khan was ordered to attack Bengal, but Daud compromised with him on the advice of minister Lodi. Later, Lodi was killed in 1573 A.D. at the behest of Daud due to the advice of some conspirators. Munim Khan easily drove away the Afghans from Bihar. He conquered the capital of Bengal, Tanda. Then the Mughal army proceeded to Saptagram in Hooghly where the Afghans took shelter. Daud Khan fled to Orissa. But Munim Khan along with many Mughal soldiers died of plague. Consequently there were disorder and anarchy. Taking advantage of this situation Daud Karrani again took hold of West and North Bengal. On the other hand, Issa Khan, the Zamindar of the low lying areas, drove away the Mughal soldiers from East Bengal. The Mughal soldiers then left Bengal and took shelter in Bihar.

Hearing this news, Emperor Akbar sent Khan Jahan Hussain Kuli Khan as the ruler of Bengal. Raja Todormal was appointed his assistant. Daud Karrani intercepted the Mughal soldiers at Rajmahal, the Gateway to Bengal. Muzaffar Khan Tarbati, ruler of Bihar came to the aid of the Mughals. In 1576 A.D. a fierce battle was fought between the Mughals and the Afghans near Rajmahal. Daud Karrani suffered a crushing defeat and was sentenced to death. Thus the Mughal rule was introduced in Bengal. Of course, the Mughal rule could not be extended very far in the face of the resistance offered by the 'Barabhuynas'.

The History of Barabhuynas

Emperor Akbar could not establish authority over the whole of Bengal. The big Zamindars of Bengal did not accept the subordination of the Mughals. The independent and powerful Zamindars fought united against the Mughal commanders to protect their land. They were

known as Barabhuyinas, where 'Bara' does not mean the number of twelve, rather defines the indefinite number of Zamindars.

Issa Khan was the Zamindar of Sonargaon, the low land known as 'Vati' region and the leader of Barabhuyinas. He was loyal to the Karrani Dynasty. The Gazi family established their Zamindari in Bhawal before the conquest of Bengal by Sher Shah. Similarly, big Zamindaries were established in the regions of Faridpur, Sylhet, Mymensingh, Vikrampur, Barisal, Noakhali, Manikganj, etc.

Emperor Akbar gave special attention to subdue the Barabhuyinas. He sent Shahbaz Khan in 1583 A.D., Sadiq Khan in 1585 A.D., Uzir Khan in 1586 A.D. and Raja Mansingh in 1594 A.D. as Subadars in Bengal. They fought a number of battles with Issa Khan and other Zamindars. But they could not defeat him. After Issa Khan's death in 1599 A.D. his son Musa Khan became the leader of the Barabhuyinas. Mansingh was sent to Bengal for the second time in 1601 A.D. But he had to return to Delhi hearing the news of Akbar's illness before the final success achieved.

After the death of Akbar, Jahangir became the Mughal Emperor. During his reign Barabhuyinas were subdued completely. The claimant of the success was Subadar Islam Khan (1608-1613 A.D.). He shifted the capital of Bengal from Rajmahal to Dhaka with the intention of suppressing the Barabhuyinas. Musa Khan's base was at Sonargaon, not far from Dhaka. On his way from Rajmahal to Dhaka, Islam Khan won the allegiance of many Zamindars on the way. He built a strong navy to face the Barabhuyinas. The first fight with Musa Khan took place in 1609 A.D. in Jatrapur on the eastern bank of the River Karotoa. Musa Khan had a fort there. In the battle that followed, Musa Khan and other Zamindars were forced to retreat. Islam Khan entered Dhaka in 1610 A.D. From this time Dhaka became the capital of Bengal and was named Jahangirnagar after the Emperor.

The naval force of the Zamindars assembled on the river Sitalakhya under the leadership of Musa Khan. The fort 'Kadam Rasul' of Musa Khan, situated on the eastern bank of the river was captured by the Mughals. Musa Khan retreated to Sonargaon. The Mughal soldiers finally occupied Sonargaon. Thereafter the Zamindars were forced to surrender. Subadar Islam Khan was very generous. He behaved very courteously with Musa Khan. He appointed Musa Khan in his own Zamindari as a representative of the Mughals. Musa Khan passed the rest of his life as a loyal representative of the Mughals.

Many Zamindars were disappointed at the surrender of Musa Khan. After that all other Zamindars pledged allegiance to the Mughals one after another. This ended the rule of the Barabhuyinas.

The Mughal Rule in Bengal

The rule of the Mughals in Bengal was divided into two periods.

1. **Rule of the Subadars:** The Mughal provinces were known as 'Subas'. Bengal became a Suba after the defeat of the Barabhuynas. Its golden phase was from early seventeenth to early eighteenth century. After Aurangzeb, the Mughal rule in Bengal became weak in the hands of his weak successors. Taking advantage of this, the Subadars of Bengal were ruling independently.
2. **Rule of the Nawabs:** The independent rule of the Subadars is known as the rule of the Nawabs. This continued upto 1757 A.D. for almost half a century.

The Rule of the Subadars in Bengal

Islam Khan introduced the rule of the Subadars in Bengal in 1610 A.D. after having suppressed the Barabhuynas. Many Subadars ruled in Bengal, but no one could succeed before Mir Jumla's reign. The description is as follows:

Islam Khan (1610-1613 A.D.): The first Subadar in Bengal.

Islam Khan Chisti (1613-1617 A.D.): Ascended the throne after Islam Khan's death.

Ibrahim Khan Fateh Jang (1617-1624 A.D.): Brother of Empress Nurjahan of Delhi. He was succeeded by **Darar Khan**, **Mohabbat Khan**, **Mukarram Khan** and **Fidai Khan** (1624-1628 A.D.).

Kasem Khan Juini (1628-1635 A.D.): Appointed by Emperor Shahjahan. The Portuguese increased greatly in number and eventually posed a threat to Bengal since the time of Hussain Shah. Kasem Khan suppressed them with a strong hand.

Islam Khan Mashadi (1635-1639 A.D.): Ruled for four years.

Shah Suja (1639-1659 A.D.): Second son of Emperor Shahjahan. Quite peaceful reign. The English merchants enjoyed special favours during this time, and they increased their power. When Emperor Shahjahan fell sick in 1657 A.D., his four sons revolted because each wanted to be the Emperor. In the battle of the two brothers, Aurangzeb and Shah Suja, Suja was defeated in 1659 A.D.

Mir Jumla (1660-1663 A.D.): Came to Bengal to subdue Suja. Emperor Aurangzeb made him the Subadar of Bengal. As an efficient Subadar, he annexed Assam and Cooch Bihar to the Mughal Empire. Was succeeded by Dilir Khan and Daud Khan Abbasi after his death.

Shayesta Khan (1664-1678 A.D., September 1679-1688 A.D.): Maternal uncle of Aurangzeb, a very efficient and farsighted administrator. He drove away the Portuguese pirates and

occupied Chittagong. Towards the end of his reign, there was a dispute with the *English East India Company*. After a prolonged attempt he drove away the English from Bengal stopping the growth of their power. After him, Khan Jahan Bahadur, Ibrahim Khan and Azimuddin became Subadars (1688-1717), but were not very efficient.

Murshid Kuli Khan (1717-1727 A.D.): Formerly Diwan of Bengal came to power as an efficient Subadar during the reign of Emperor Farruk Shiar. Famous for the reformation of revenue system.

After the death of Aurangzeb, the weak emperors could not give attention to the distant Subas. So the Subadars were quite independent. Murshid Kuli Khan was not any difference. He pledged loyalty to the Emperor only by name and used to send him an amount of one crore three lakhs rupees annually as taxes. From his time Bengal was almost independent the rule of the Nawabs started.

The Rule of the Nawabs (1727-1757 A.D.)

This period is known as the “Nawabat of Bengal”. Suba was then called ‘Nizamat’ and the post of the Subadar was called ‘Nazim’. It became hereditary. The Nazims only received a letter of authority from the Mughal Emperor on ascending the throne. Murshid Kuli Khan was the first Nazim of Bengal.

Sujauddin Khan (1727-1739 A.D.): The husband of Murshid Kuli’s daughter Zinat-un-Nessa, as Murshid Kuli had no son. He was the first independent Nawab of Bengal, Bihar and Orissa. Appointed his relatives and trustworthy people in high officers; had good relations with the Zamindars. But in his later life he faced many conspiracies of his courtiers, though he faced them boldly.

Sarfaraz Khan (1739-1740 A.D.): Son of Sujauddin, an inefficient ruler. The whole country was in disorder. Was succeeded by Alivardi Khan.

Alivardi Khan (1740-1756 A.D.): Took the power of Bengal not by the authority of the Mughal Emperor, but by sheer power of arms. He established peace in Bengal. From 1742 A.D. to 1751 A.D. he fought for ten years and finally made the Marathi bandits ‘Bargis’ leave the country. He suppressed the revolting Afghan soldiers with a strong hand. He also checked the activities of many European merchants who began to gather military power.

Siraj-ud-Doula (1756-1757 A.D.): Son of the youngest daughter of Alivardi Khan, Amena Begum. Was nominated by Alivardi Khan. The first daughter of Alivardi, Ghasheti Begum started conspiracy to see Shaukat Jang, the son of her second sister, as the Nawab. She gained the support from some nobles. Roy Durlav, Jagat Seth, Mir Zafar, Umi Chand, Raj Ballav, etc. were among them. The English merchants manipulated the court politics. They joined hands with the conspirators.

The Battle of Plassey

A battle between the Nawabs and the English was inevitable. Thus, in 1757, the famous Battle of Plassey began. Mir Zafar, the Commander-in-Chief of the Nawab absented himself from taking part in the battle. Everything was the conspiracy of the English merchants and the fraud nobles. Siraj-ud-Doula suffered defeat miserably. He tried to save his life by escaping from Murshidabad. But he was caught, and ultimately was murdered by Muhammadi Beg.

Conclusion

With the death of Nawab Siraj-ud-Doula, the foundation of the English rule was laid. The merchants of English East India Company established the English rule in Bengal by annihilating the conspirators one by one. Thus Bengal lost her independence through the Battle of Plassey, which worked as the foundation of the two hundred years long European Colonization in the Indian subcontinent.